# Meghana Gaur

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| **Placement Director** | Gianluca Violante | violante@princeton.edu | 609-258-4003 |
| **Graduate Administrator** | Laura Hedden | lhedden@princeton.edu | 609-258-4006 |

## Office Contact Information

Julis Romo Rabinowitz Building
Department of Economics
Princeton University
Princeton, NJ 08544

## Graduate Studies

**Princeton University** *2021–present*

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics
Expected Completion Date: 2027

## References

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Professor John Grigsby** | **Professor Richard Rogerson** | **Professor Ayşegül Şahin** |
| Department of Economics | Department of Economics | Department of Economics |
| Princeton University | Princeton University | Princeton University |
| john.grigsby@princeton.edu | rdr@princeton.edu | aysegul.sahin@princeton.edu |

## Prior Education

**Rice University** *2015–2019*

B.A. in Mathematics and Mathematical Economic Analysis (Honors), *magna cum laude*

## Fields

**Primary** Macroeconomics, Labor Economics, Technological Change

**Secondary** International Trade

## Job Market Paper

"On-the-job Learning and Automation in Career Paths"

*The task content of work changes over the life cycle. This paper studies how on-the-job learning within career paths shapes the individual and labor market impacts of automation shocks. I develop a dynamic general equilibrium model in which young workers sort into occupations that differ in their opportunities for human capital accumulation. Combining the structure of the model with large-scale résumé data, I recover a flexible on-the-job learning technology that rationalizes early-career occupational transitions. The recovered learning estimates are associated with measures of knowledge proximity and industry overlap, consistent with domain-specific human capital. The model shows how an automation shock to one occupation can induce automation further up the career ladder. For a broad automation shock, I find that initial career choices offer an important margin of long run labor-supply flexibility, dampening the pass-through of automation exposure to relative skill prices by roughly 40%.*

## Working Papers

1. "Bonus Question: How Does Flexible Incentive Pay Affect Unemployment Dynamics?" With John Grigsby, Jonathon Hazell, and Abdoulaye Ndiaye. 2026. *Forthcoming at American Economic Review: Insights.*

   *We introduce dynamic incentive contracts into a model of unemployment fluctuations. Our main result is that wage cyclicality from incentives does not affect the response of unemployment to productivity shocks. The response of unemployment is the same, to a first-order, in two economies: one with flexible incentive pay, and another with exogenously fixed wages. This equivalence is due to movements in effort. Under the optimal incentive contract, firms' profits do not change when wages fall, because the effort of the worker falls too.*

2. "Lifecycle Dynamics in Technology Adoption." With Alicia Zhang. 2026.

   *Who drives the diffusion of new technologies? We provide novel evidence that more experienced software developers use newer programming languages than their less experienced counterparts. Leveraging panel data on individual-level programming activity, we find that developers continue to adopt newer languages as they gain more coding experience. The fact that less experienced developers use older languages is surprising, as we also show that newer languages offer a salary premium. We interpret these facts through the lens of a directed job search model featuring an individual technology adoption decision. In the model, workers must pay costs to switch technology vintages. Newer technologies offer higher wages and a lower cost of switching to the technological frontier, which incentivizes continuous upgrading. Shocks that reduce aggregate productivity, increase worker turnover, and reduce labor market matching efficiency slow the diffusion of new technologies.*

## Work in Progress

1. "Occupational Heterogeneity in Trends in the Earnings Cost of Job Loss"
2. "Labor Market Dynamics of US Inventors." With Xiang Zhang.
3. "Too Costly to Fire: Automation and Re-training with Labor Adjustment Costs." With Agustín Barboza.

## Research Experience

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| 2024 | Research Assistant to Prof. Ezra Oberfield |
| 2022 | Research Assistant to Prof. John Grigsby |
| 2019–2021 | Senior Research Analyst, Federal Reserve Bank of New York |

## Teaching

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| *Princeton* | SPI 512C: Macroeconomic Analysis for Policymakers—Advanced Track (TA, 2025) |
| *Rice* | MATH 354: Honors Linear Algebra (Grader, 2018) |
| | ECON 200: Microeconomics (TA, 2017–2019) |

## Professional Activities

### Invited Presentations

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| 2026 | PhD Workshop in Labor and Behavioral Economics, CEBI |
| 2025 | Society for Economic Dynamics Annual Meeting |

## Honors, Scholarships, Fellowships, and Grants

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| Princeton Data Driven Social Sciences Grant | *2026* |
| Princeton Program for Research on Inequality Research Grant | *2026* |
| Stripe Economics of AI Fellowship | *2025* |
| Princeton International Economics Section Summer Fellowship | *2024* |
| Princeton University Graduate Fellowship | *2021–2027* |
| National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship | *2021–2026* |
| Phi Beta Kappa Honor Society, Rice University | *2019* |
| Gaston Rimlinger Prize in Economics (Best Senior Thesis), Rice University | *2019* |

## Additional Information

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| **Skills** | Bash/Shell, MATLAB, LaTeX, Julia, Python, SQL, Stata |
| **Citizenship** | USA |

*Last updated: October 2026*